

you should call the bank directly, using a number that you know is valid (don't use a phone number provided in the e-mail). If there really is a problem, they'll be able to help you on the phone.

Other attacks involve stealing your information from your computer. Software programs may track your communication or your keystrokes, and send that information off to a scammer. To protect yourself from this type of scam, keep your computer secure. Use antivirus and firewall software, and keep other software (browsers, operating system, etc.) up-to-date. For the most part, you can avoid problems by avoiding shady websites and never opening e-mail attachments from people you don't trust.

Finally, keep a close watch on your bank accounts and keep a tight lid on your banking information. Simply telling somebody your account number can expose you to problems, so don't divulge your banking information over the phone or via the web unless you know whom you're dealing with. If you suspect that somebody else is using your account, call your bank immediately.

With the Help of Software

The most popular software programs for taking advantage of online banking are Quicken and Mint. Both are robust personal-finance programs that allow you to download your banking transactions and help to manage your finances, budget, balance your checkbook, pay bills electronically, prepare and file your taxes, track investments, and build a financial plan for your future.